

The Third and Fourth Larut Wars Reconsidered:

Continuity, Maritime Mobilisation, Economic Rivalry and Colonial Crisis
Management in 1872–1874

*A Historical Reconsideration Based on Contemporaneous Colonial
Correspondence*

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Abstract

This study reconsiders the commonly accepted separation of the Third and Fourth Larut Wars through an examination of contemporaneous British colonial correspondence relating to Larut, Perak, Penang, and the Straits Settlements between 1872 and 1874. Drawing primarily upon Colonial Office (CO) records, telegrams, memoranda, despatches, and administrative reports, the study suggests that the later Larut disturbances were more continuous and interconnected than many later historical narratives have portrayed.

The surviving correspondence documents armed mobilisation, maritime movement between Penang and Larut, commercial disruption, factional regrouping, and continuing British concern regarding regional instability and trade. The records also reveal the important role played by Penang-based support networks and by Captain T. C. S. Speedy during the continuing disturbances.

This study further re-examines several later historical narratives against contemporaneous archival evidence. The examined records suggest that certain commonly repeated interpretations concerning the causes, factional alignments, and development of the later Larut disturbances may oversimplify or materially differ from the surviving correspondence produced during the conflicts themselves.

By foregrounding contemporaneous archival material, this study contributes toward a more nuanced historiographical understanding of the political, economic, and administrative conditions surrounding the later Larut conflicts and the gradual expansion of British intervention in Perak prior to the Pangkor Treaty of 1874.

Rather than offering a comprehensive narrative of the later Larut Wars, this study re-examines the continuity of the 1872–1874 disturbances through contemporaneous Colonial Office correspondence and considers the implications of that evidence for the conventional distinction between the Third and Fourth Larut Wars.

Keywords: Larut Wars; 1872; 1874; Third Larut War; Fourth Larut War; Laroot; Perak; Captain T. C. S. Speedy; Hai San; Ghee Hin; Pangkor Treaty; British Malaya; Colonial Office records; contemporaneous evidence; historiography.

Sources and Methodology

This study is based primarily upon contemporaneous British colonial correspondence contained within the Colonial Office (CO) records relating to Larut, Perak, Penang, and the Straits Settlements during the disturbances of the early 1870s.

All CO references in this paper refer to records held at The National Archives (United Kingdom), Colonial Office series.

The Colonial Office records examined in this study were accessed through the Gale Primary Sources platform. Researchers should note that Gale image numbering may differ from the original pagination or folio numbering of the archival records.

The archival material examined includes:

- police reports,
- administrative despatches,
- intelligence-related correspondence,
- memoranda,
- telegraphic communications,
- Colonial Office minutes,
- and communications involving Captain T. C. S. Speedy and colonial officials stationed in Penang and Larut.

Particular reliance has been placed upon records within:

- CO 273/5 relating to the 1861 disturbances,
- CO 273/61 relating to the disturbances of 1872,
- CO 273/74 relating to the continuing disturbances and British assessments of 1873,
- and CO 273/75 relating to the settlement proceedings and intervention discussions of January 1874.

The records examined provide substantial contemporaneous material relating to the continuing disturbances, administrative responses, and political developments surrounding Larut between 1872 and 1874. Further examination of related Colonial Office files may provide additional contextual detail to the broader historical picture.

Introduction

The Larut Wars are commonly presented in later historical writing by historians such as R. O. Winstedt, Khoo Kay Kim and Wong Choon San as a sequence of four separate conflicts between rival Chinese secret society factions in nineteenth-century Perak. These are usually identified as the First Larut War (1861), Second Larut War (1865), Third Larut War (1871–1872), and Fourth Larut War (1873–1874), each associated with specific trigger events such as disputes over mining water rights, gambling disagreements, factional rivalries, or personal disputes.¹

The contemporaneous colonial correspondence, however, suggests a more prolonged and interconnected sequence of disturbances than many later simplified narratives imply.² Rather than describing clearly separated wars divided by stable intervals of peace, the records instead portray continuing instability characterised by recurring mobilisation, commercial disruption and regional insecurity affecting both Perak and the Straits Settlements.

This study is based primarily on contemporaneous correspondence contained within the British Colonial Office records relating to Larut and the Straits Settlements, particularly CO 273/61, CO 273/74, and CO 273/75. The material includes police reports, intelligence summaries, administrative despatches, telegraphic correspondence, internal Colonial Office minutes, and communications involving Captain Tristram Charles Sawyer Speedy (commonly known as Captain Speedy), a British officer closely involved in policing, military, and administrative operations relating to Larut during the disturbances of the early 1870s.³

Taken together, the evidence suggests that the later Larut disturbances formed successive phases within a broader regional crisis whose political and military consequences culminated in the Pangkor settlement.

¹ Representative accounts adopting the conventional four-war chronology and its associated trigger narratives include Winstedt and Wilkinson (1974, 78–90), Khoo Kay Kim (1975, 128–130, 135–138, 167–175, 176–185), and Wong Choon San (2024, 91–96).

² British Colonial Office Records, CO 273/61, correspondence and despatches relating to the Larut disturbances, October 1872; see also CO 273/74, pp. 284–285, describing Perak as remaining “in a state of Anarchy for more than a year,” together with related Colonial Office correspondence in CO 273/75 concerning continuing disturbances, British intervention and administrative negotiations in Perak during 1873–1874.

³ CO 273/61; CO 273/74; CO 273/75. Correspondence involving Captain T. C. S. Speedy, Straits Settlements officials, Colonial Office minutes and reports concerning disturbances in Larut and Penang.

Economic Rivalry and the Expanding Conflict Environment

The evidence contained within CO 273/5 strongly suggests that economic rivalry surrounding the tin mining industry formed a central component of the earlier Larut disturbances.

In the case of the First Larut War (1861), contemporaneous reports referred to disputes involving mining water supply. The correspondence described allegations that Hai San men interfered with or cut water courses supplying Ghee Hin mining operations, resulting in retaliatory fighting, destruction of mining works, looting, and displacement of miners.⁴

The records repeatedly emphasised the importance of water supply to alluvial tin mining operations. Control of mining water infrastructure effectively meant control over mining production itself.

The disturbances also appear to have expanded rapidly beyond isolated local quarrels. British reports referred to organised mobilisation of armed Hai San men, concealed weapons aboard junks, maritime transport of armed reinforcements, movement of armed groups between Penang and Larut, and British fears that wider disorder might spread into Penang itself.⁵

The evidence therefore suggests that the earlier Larut disturbances were closely connected to broader struggles involving mining production, labour control, commercial competition, and factional influence within the rapidly expanding tin industry.

The same broader pattern appears again within the disturbances of 1872.

The memorandum sequence within CO 273/61 referred not only to gambling disputes, but also to factional mobilisation, struggles over mines and property.⁶ One contemporaneous memorandum stated that “Khoo Ah Choey and his partner, Lew Ah Sam had also great loss.”⁷ Read within the wider context of continuing violence, disruption of mining operations, destruction of property, and labour displacement, the memorandum strongly suggests that commercial losses formed an important part of the wider conflict environment.

The records also discussed attempts to recover mines and property, factional regrouping, and support from wealthy and influential figures in Penang.⁸ One report stated that the

⁴ CO 273/5, pp. 829, 835, 900, 908.

⁵ CO 273/5, pp. 831, 843, 845, 847.

⁶ CO 273/61, pp. 494-498.

⁷ CO 273/61, p. 495.

⁸ CO 273/61, pp. 496-497.

Ghee Hin had “been on the alert for months” to recover their possessions and were allegedly supported by “wealthy and influential men in Penang.”⁹

Additional material within CO 273/74 strengthens this picture further. Administrative reports from 1873 described Perak as remaining “in a state of Anarchy for more than a year,” while also referring to repeated cycles of fighting in which defeated factions regrouped, obtained reinforcements, and resumed warfare.¹⁰ One memorandum stated that the defeated faction had obtained “...money from Penang and men and arms from China and England.”¹¹ Another described the conflict as a continuing struggle in which “...the game goes on, with so far no appearance of coming to an end.”¹²

The reports also referred to devastation of the countryside, distress among Malay inhabitants, destruction of mining districts, and continuing fears that instability might spread into Penang itself.¹³

Taken together, the evidence indicates that the later Larut disturbances emerged within a much broader environment of commercial rivalry, factional competition, organised mobilisation, and continuing regional instability extending far beyond a single isolated dispute.

Lew Ah Sam and Continuing Commercial Activity During the Disturbances

The surviving records also contain an important contemporaneous reference to Lew Ah Sam during the disturbances of 1872.

The memorandum referring to the losses suffered by “Khoo Ah Choey and his partner, Lew Ah Sam” suggests that Lew Ah Sam continued to hold significant commercial interests during the later Larut disturbances rather than disappearing from the historical record after the Second Larut War, as some later narratives have implied.¹⁴

Additional reports associated with Captain T. C. S. Speedy appear to refer to a “Loo Sam Hap” among the “Hy-san” headmen connected to the disturbances. The name may plausibly represent a phonetic rendering of Lew Ah Sam within the fluid transliteration practices commonly found in nineteenth-century colonial correspondence relating to Chinese names in the Straits Settlements and Malaya.

⁹ CO 273/61, pp. 496.

¹⁰ CO 273/74, pp. 284-285.

¹¹ CO 273/74, p. 285.

¹² CO 273/74, p. 285.

¹³ CO 273/74, pp. 285-286.

¹⁴ CO 273/61, p. 496.

Although the surviving records do not conclusively establish the identification, the correspondence nevertheless suggests that Lew Ah Sam continued to occupy a commercially and operationally significant position within the Larut mining environment during the disturbances of the early 1870s.

This is historically significant because several later narratives have tended to treat Lew Ah Sam primarily within the context of the earlier Larut disturbances. The contemporaneous evidence instead suggests a more extended continuity of involvement.

The Affair Narrative and Wider Factional Tensions

Later secondary narratives, including those of Winstedt, Khoo Kay Kim and Wong Choon San, have frequently described the Third Larut War as having been triggered primarily by an affair involving a woman connected to rival Chinese factions.

Later historical accounts have frequently elaborated this episode through the story of Lee Ah Kun. A direct examination of L. H. Wynne's *Triad and Tabut* likewise shows that Wynne questioned the alleged affair traditionally associated with the narrative, describing it as "difficult to accept as genuine", while discussing the episode within the broader context of Triad–Tokong rivalry.¹⁵

The contemporaneous records do contain references supporting the existence of such an interpersonal dispute. One memorandum referred to a murder connected to a man described as having "...had dealings with a See Yip woman."¹⁶

The memorandum sequence, however, placed much greater emphasis upon economic rivalry, factional politics, gambling disputes, recovery of mines and property, organised mobilisation, and continuing instability.

The affair narrative therefore appears, at least on the basis of the surviving evidence, to have represented one contributing spark within a much wider conflict environment already shaped by deeper commercial and factional tensions.

The memorandum sequence also discussed the "See Yips" and the "In Tye Yons." Captain Speedy reportedly identified the "See Yips" with the "Gehinns" (Ghee Hins) and the "In Tye Yons" with the "Hysans" (Hai Sans).¹⁷

¹⁵ L. H. Wynne, *Triad and Tabut: A Survey of the Origin and Diffusion of Chinese and Mohamedan Secret Societies in the Malay Peninsula, 1800–1935* (Singapore: Government Printer, 1941), pp. 266, 276. Wynne recounted the traditional narrative concerning Lee Ah Kun (p. 266) but later observed that the alleged "intrigue with the wife of a near relative of Chang Keng Kwi" was "difficult to accept as genuine" (p. 276), placing the episode within the wider context of Triad–Tokong rivalry rather than treating it as the principal cause of the conflict.

¹⁶ CO 273/61, pp. 496–497.

¹⁷ CO 273/61, pp. 496–497.

The contemporaneous material also appears to differ in important respects from several later secondary retellings of the affair narrative. Later accounts have frequently described the dispute as involving a Ghee Hin leader and the wife of a relative connected to the Hai San leadership. The examined memorandum sequence, however, referred instead to a man who had "dealings with a See Yip woman," while Captain T. C. S. Speedy's accompanying factional identifications indicate a Hai San-associated man and a Ghee Hin (See Yip) woman. This interpretation is independently corroborated by Frank Swettenham's *Perak Journals* (January 1874), which records that the affair involved "a Si Quan woman" and "a Gho Quan man," with Ah Yam representing the Si Quans and Ah Quee representing the Gho Quans.¹⁸ Together, these two contemporaneous sources differ from the reverse factional alignment commonly repeated in many later secondary narratives.

The distinction is historically significant because it indicates that later narratives may not have preserved the original factional relationships described in the contemporaneous records.

Maritime Mobilisation and the Penang–Larut Connection

One of the most striking features of the contemporaneous correspondence is its consistent reference to maritime mobilisation linking Penang and Larut.

The records describe armed junks, steam launches, transport of weapons, movement of armed men, and organised maritime movement between Penang and Larut.¹⁹ British officials also expressed concern that intervention against such vessels might provoke wider violence beyond their immediate capacity to control.

Captain T. C. S. Speedy appears prominently within several reports discussing armed movement, witness testimony concerning firearms, the arrival of Chinese factions from Penang, and fears that forceful intervention might produce serious "collision" with organised Chinese groups.

Several reports indicate that colonial authorities deliberately avoided direct confrontation against armed junks or organised parties because they feared escalation.

The records consistently portray Penang not merely as a passive observer but as a logistical, financial, and political centre connected to the disturbances in Larut.

One report within CO 273/74 stated that the Larut mines were worked by Chinese miners "...whose head men belong to Penang and who work with capital obtained from Penang."²⁰ The same records referred to wounded men arriving in Penang, fears of Chinese outbreaks

¹⁸ Frank Swettenham, "Journal for 23 January to 27 February 1874," in P. L. Burns and C. D. Cowan (eds.), *Sir Frank Swettenham's Malayan Journals, 1874–1876* (Kuala Lumpur: Oxford University Press, 1975), pp. 40–42. Swettenham recorded the account during January–February 1874 from Ah Yam, whom he identified as the Chinese Commissioner representing the Si Quans.

¹⁹ CO 273/74, p. 284.

²⁰ CO 273/74, pp. 284–286.

within George Town and continuing British concern that violence in Larut might spread into the island itself.²¹

Collectively, the references to influential Penang supporters, maritime transport, armed arrivals, refugee flows, and financial backing indicate that the disturbances operated through interconnected regional networks extending well beyond Larut itself.

Captain Speedy, Military Recruitment and Continuing Conflict

The evidence for continuing regional mobilisation becomes even clearer within the correspondence relating to Captain Speedy's recruitment activities during 1873.

Additional contemporaneous correspondence within CO 273/75 further reinforces this interpretation by documenting organised regional mobilisation connected to the Larut disturbances.²²

A series of despatches and telegrams from September and October 1873 discussed the proposed enlistment and embarkation of Punjabees, Sepoys, and police mantries for service under Captain Tristram Charles Sawyer Speedy in Larut.²³

The correspondence described how Captain Speedy sought to recruit armed manpower at Calcutta for service under the Raja of Larut during continuing disturbances involving Chinese factions.²⁴

One telegram dated 15 September 1873 stated:

"Is Laroot Rajah engaging Punjabees Soldiers what purpose."

"Is Laroot fighting with Perak Sultan or whom."²⁵

Additional correspondence explained that the ruler of Larut was:

"...endeavouring to drive out of his country certain lawless bands of Chinese who are fighting there."²⁶

The same memorandum sequence referred to Captain Speedy obtaining approximately one hundred men and discussed whether the embarkation of these forces should be prohibited or permitted.²⁷

²¹ CO 273/74, pp. 284- 286.

²² CO 273/75/12, pp. 127-133.

²³ CO 273/75/12, pp. 129-133.

²⁴ CO 273/75/12, pp. 127-132.

²⁵ CO 273/75/12, p. 126.

²⁶ CO 273/75/12, pp. 129-130.

²⁷ CO 273/75/12, pp. 131-133.

Particularly significant is the repeated statement by Straits Settlements officials that Government had "no objection" to Speedy obtaining assistance for the Raja of Larut, although he was informed that he acted "on his own responsibility."²⁸

Other correspondence within the same sequence stated that approximately one hundred Punjabees had already been embarked by Captain Speedy for service connected to Larut after initial objections concerning their departure had been withdrawn.²⁹

The records also referred to uncertainty regarding "Captain Speedy's movements and intentions," suggesting that British authorities themselves were not exercising complete centralised control over the continuing military-style mobilisation taking place as late as September and October 1873.³⁰

Rather than describing a clearly concluded conflict followed by a separate later war, the correspondence describes ongoing fighting, recruitment of armed manpower, attempts to recover territory, and continuing British concern over whether such intervention should be restrained or tolerated.

Taken together, this evidence indicates that the disturbances were still unfolding as an active and unstable security crisis well into late 1873 rather than as a clearly concluded war followed by a separate later conflict.

From Continuing Disturbance to Political Settlement

The records contained within CO 273/75 provide important insight into the transition from continuing warfare toward political settlement during January 1874.

A series of telegrams and despatches dated 23–24 January 1874 referred to the "unconditional surrender" of the Chinese factions in Larut and described how both sides were being disarmed while their stockades were destroyed.³¹

The same correspondence referred to the return of women and children captured during the fighting, collective peace bonds imposed upon the Chinese headmen and guarantees reportedly provided by wealthy Chinese residents in Penang.³²

The records also reveal how closely the Larut settlement process had become intertwined with the Perak succession dispute. One despatch stated that the principal Malay chiefs of Perak had recognised Raja Muda Abdullah as Sultan while simultaneously requesting the residence of British officers to advise upon administration and revenue matters.³³

²⁸ CO 273/75/12, pp. 123–124.

²⁹ CO 273/75/12, pp. 132–133.

³⁰ CO 273/75/12, pp. 123–126.

³¹ CO 273/75/7, pp. 81–84.

³² CO 273/75/7, pp. 81–84.

³³ CO 273/75/7, p. 84.

The evidence therefore indicates that by January 1874 the Larut settlement process had become inseparably connected to wider political, commercial, and administrative developments affecting Perak and the Straits Settlements.

Several internal Colonial Office minutes further reveal that British officials regarded the question of appointing Residents as highly important and requiring cautious deliberation. One minute referred to the necessity of avoiding “...a false move.”³⁴ Another internal memorandum expressed hope that peace and trade might be restored “...without unduly compromising the Government in the internal affairs of these States.”³⁵

These discussions are historically significant because they suggest that British intervention in Perak was still being debated cautiously within the imperial administration even while local settlement arrangements were already unfolding.

At the same time, the records indicate that British authorities were already deeply involved in the political, security, commercial, and maritime affairs surrounding Larut and the Straits Settlements prior to the Pangkor settlement. Their caution appears to have stemmed less from reluctance to involve themselves in local affairs than from concern over assuming deeper formal responsibility and the wider political, military, and financial consequences that more direct intervention in Perak might produce.

The disturbances therefore appear to have formed part of a broader process through which British political intervention and eventual Residential governance began emerging within the Malay States.

Reconsidering the Boundary Between the Third and Fourth Larut Wars

One of the most significant observations emerging from the contemporaneous correspondence is the apparent absence of a clearly identifiable peaceful interval separating the later phase of the Third Larut War from the disturbances later categorised as the Fourth Larut War.

Earlier Larut disturbances appear to have been separated by more recognisable periods of reduced large-scale violence.

The disturbances from 1872 onward, however, increasingly resemble a continuing cycle of intermittent warfare, mobilisation, regrouping, maritime reinforcement, renewed fighting, and recurring instability. Such developments appear throughout the correspondence alongside growing administrative concern regarding security and public order.³⁶

³⁴ CO 273/75/8, pp. 86–89.

³⁵ CO 273/75/8, p. 89.

³⁶ CO 273/74, pp. 284–286, CO 273/75/8, 'Proceedings at Larut' despatches and Colonial Office minutes, pp. 86–89.

The evidence relating to maritime reinforcement, recruitment of armed manpower, continuing factional warfare and British tolerance of semi-independent intervention activities further strengthens the impression of an ongoing and evolving regional crisis rather than two neatly separated wars.

The tone of the reports strongly suggests that British officials themselves experienced the situation not as separate wars with clear beginnings and endings, but as a prolonged and unstable security crisis extending across multiple years.

This interpretation does not deny that significant escalations or renewed outbreaks occurred during the period. The records nevertheless suggest that the disturbances traditionally divided into the “Third” and “Fourth” Larut Wars may have represented successive phases within a continuing conflict environment rather than entirely separate wars divided by prolonged stable peace.

The Pangkor settlement of 1874 therefore appears, from the contemporaneous material examined, to have emerged not merely as a response to a single disturbance but as the culmination of prolonged instability shaped by recurring warfare, commercial disruption, regional insecurity, maritime mobilisation, and growing British concern regarding order and trade throughout Perak and the Straits Settlements.

Conclusion

The contemporaneous colonial correspondence examined in this study suggests that the later Larut disturbances were more continuous and interconnected than many later historical narratives have portrayed, while also revealing stronger evidence of sustained economic rivalry, organised mobilisation, and wider political consequences than those narratives generally acknowledge.

Rather than representing entirely separate and neatly compartmentalised wars, the surviving records point towards a prolonged regional crisis characterised by recurring violence, commercial disruption, armed mobilisation, political uncertainty, and continuing intervention by both local and colonial actors.

The correspondence consistently portrays instability extending between Larut and Penang through maritime movement, influential commercial networks, refugee flows, armed reinforcement, and continuing attempts by rival factions to recover territory, labour, and influence.

The surviving records also suggest that British involvement in Larut evolved gradually rather than emerging suddenly after the Pangkor Treaty of 1874.

The correspondence reflects a progressive expansion of British activity through operational improvisation, tolerated military assistance, frontier policing and increasingly formal political intervention before these developments later crystallised into the Residential system.

The examined correspondence further suggests that the Larut disturbances formed part of a broader turning point in British imperial policy toward the Malay States, where commercial anxieties, political instability, regional security concerns and administrative experimentation increasingly converged with expanding British influence in Perak.

Taken together, the surviving contemporaneous evidence supports the possibility that the later phases of the Larut disturbances may be better understood not as entirely separate wars divided by prolonged periods of peace but as interconnected stages within a continuing regional crisis that ultimately contributed to the transformation of British political involvement in the Malay Peninsula.

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